# Old Sturgeon

Issue No. 2
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## Strangers in a Strange Wetland

## Monologue #1:
## Strangers in a Strange Wetland

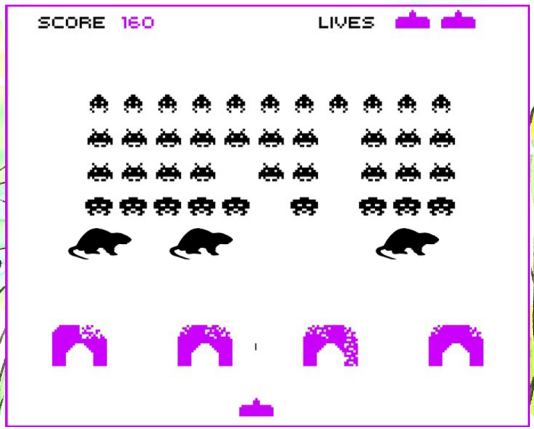
I was munching on a cattail shoot under the boardwalk in Westmoreland Park, when I heard a person crying out, "Look, it's a beaver!"
They were referring to my spouse, who stood in the puddle, cooling off.
"That's not a beaver," said a thicker human voice, "it's a nutria."



"How do you know?" High-Pitch said.
"Look at the tail."
"Right," High-Pitch said. "What an ugly tail, like a rat's."
Ugly tail? my spouse?
"She's still very cute," High-Pitch corrected.
"Yes," a third voice entered, one with a French accent.
"But they're an invasive species."



Oh, I heard it before. Invasive, invaders, ...as if we were aliens in an old arcade game — hide behind your shields and shoot us before we hit the ground!




Our ancestors were brought here on ships from Chile, locked in cages, and put on farms, to be slaughtered for coats.

When the farmers found out our pelts weren't selling, they opened the gates, and off we went, strangers in a strange land.

Now, we are persecuted everywhere: In California, they sent Judas-nutria after us, in Maryland, dogs, and in Salem, OR, they sold our meat as gourmet steak! (Again, not a best-seller.)

In Portland, kind Portland, they put wire around plants they don't want us to eat.



Are nutrias bad, you ask? Some people say, "Yer so bad, Coypu*" because we eat roots and make dens that collapse banks. It's not my love's fault that the North American marsh plants rejuvenate so slowly after she nibbles on them with her beautiful neon orange teeth. Bring us the totora reeds of Chile that regrow overnight! (They also taste better, I'm told).

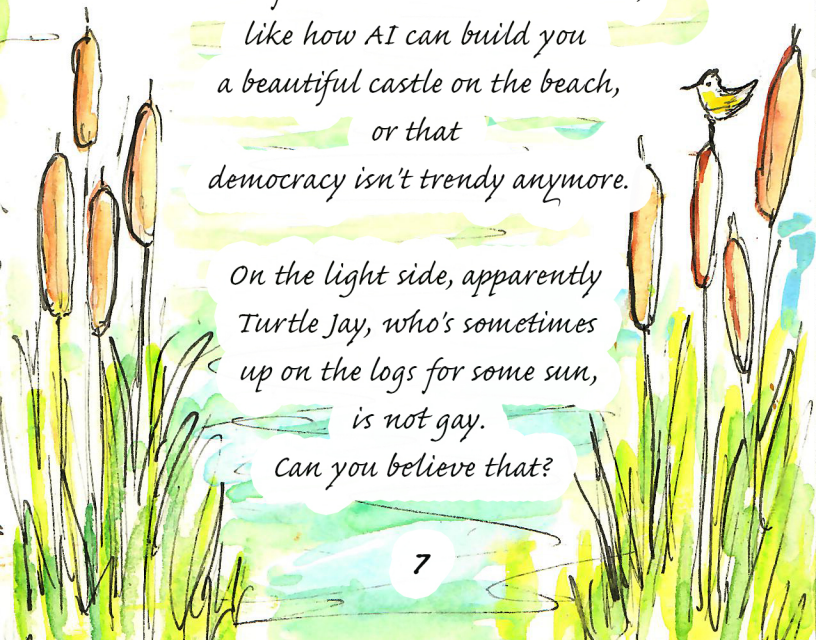
*Coypu (Myocastor coypus): Our native South American name! "Nutria" just means "otter" in Spanish, but the early fur traders weren't great at biology.



## Monologue #2: Morning Chat

Nothing is more fulfilling than sitting
with Veronica, my nutria neighbor,
for a morning chat.
She tells me what's going on in
Crystal Spring Creek,
and I feed her old news in return,
like how AI can build you
a beautiful castle on the beach,
or that
democracy isn't trendy anymore.

On the light side, apparently
Turtle Jay, who's sometimes
up on the logs for some sun,
is not gay.
Can you believe that?



So what is a Coypu, an invasive species, a refugee, a survivor, or something else? Scan the QR code and send us an email with your suggestions.
The nutria reads every message.



**Bonus Challenge:**
The names of two songs hide in the above story, one originally sung by the Drifters and the other by Tom Petty. Can you find them?

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